Chapter 49 — Push Notifications (FCM) Architecture

> **Part VI — Lifecycle, Background & Platform** · Complexity: **Complex** (≥40 interview questions)
>
> **Prerequisites:** Ch 47 (Doze/background limits), Ch 30 (WorkManager), Ch 46 (FGS), Ch 19 (auth), Ch 51 (notification permission), Ch 50 (notification inbox). Pairs with Ch 48 (alarms), Ch 32 (sync).
>
> **Reference surface in StreamCart:** server-driven real-time signals — order shipped, price drop, chat message, live-stream starting — delivered to the device promptly and reliably, turned into notifications or silent data syncs, across app states and the platform's background limits.

49.1 Problem Definition and Real-World Context

Apps constantly need the **server to reach the client** when something happens: your order shipped, a message arrived, a watched item dropped in price, a live stream is starting. The client can't poll for this — polling is blocked/deferred by Doze (Ch 47), wastes battery, and scales terribly. The platform answer is **push notifications via Firebase Cloud Messaging (FCM)**: a single OS-level, battery-efficient channel from your server through Google's infrastructure to the device, even when the app is backgrounded or killed.

FCM looks simple ("send a notification") but is a **distributed delivery system** with real engineering depth:

- **Delivery is best-effort, not guaranteed.** FCM may drop, delay, or collapse messages (especially in Doze / bad App Standby buckets, Ch 47). You cannot assume a push arrived — critical state must be **reconciled via sync** (Ch 32), with push as a *trigger*, not the source of truth.
- **Notification vs data messages, × app state.** A "notification message" is auto-displayed by the system when backgrounded but delivered to your code when foregrounded; a "data message" always goes to your code. Behavior differs across **foreground / background / killed**, and getting this matrix wrong means missed or duplicated notifications.
- **Token lifecycle.** Each app install has an FCM **registration token** that can **rotate** at any time (`onNewToken`); the server must store it per user/device, and **stale tokens** must be pruned or sends fail. Logout/account-switch (Ch 22/42) must invalidate tokens.
- **Priority & quotas. High-priority** messages can wake the app in Doze (limited, bucket-dependent quota, Ch 47); **normal-priority** may be delayed. Over-using high priority burns quota and gets throttled.
- **Security.** Payloads traverse Google's servers — **never put secrets/PII in the payload**; treat received payloads as **untrusted input**; authenticate the *effect* (fetch over authed API, Ch 19). Topic subscriptions and misrouting can leak data across users/accounts.
- **Fan-out & targeting.** Sending to millions (topics, device groups, per-user tokens) is a backend scaling problem; the client must subscribe/unsubscribe correctly and handle multi-device.

The architecture: integrate **FCM** for the transport; model **notification vs data messages** and handle each across **app states**; manage the **token lifecycle** (register, `onNewToken`, server upsert, logout invalidation, multi-device); choose

priority deliberately (high only for time-sensitive, Ch 47); **treat push as a trigger, reconcile truth via sync** (Ch 32) so dropped messages self-heal; do heavy work in **WorkManager/expedited** (Ch 30), not in the receiver; render notifications via a central **Notifier** (channels, grouping, Ch 50) gated by **notification permission** (Ch 51); and **secure** payloads (no secrets, untrusted input, authed effects, per-account isolation). This chapter is the **client-side architecture of a reliable, secure push system** — one of the most-asked Android system-design topics.

Three practical use cases

1. **StreamCart order update.** High-priority data message "order X shipped" → wake → (optionally) expedited WorkManager fetches details over authed API (Ch 19) → notification (Ch 50); truth reconciled by order sync (Ch 32) if the push was dropped.
2. **Chat message.** Data message with a lightweight signal → fetch the message, show a grouped conversation notification; mark read syncs back.
3. **Marketing / topic broadcast.** Normal-priority topic message (e.g., "flash-sale-subscribers") → notification; respects user notification preferences and consent (Ch 28/51).

Why this is architectural

Push touches the **server ↔ client contract**, **background execution limits**, **auth/ security**, **sync/consistency**, **permissions**, and **notification UX** at once. The decisions — message type, priority, token management, trigger-vs-truth, payload security, fan-out — determine whether real-time features are reliable, battery-friendly, secure, and correct across every app state and device.

49.2 Requirements Engineering

Functional requirements

ID	Requirement
F1	Receive server-driven messages across foreground/background/killed states.
F2	Manage FCM token lifecycle (register, rotate, server upsert, invalidate on logout).
F3	Turn messages into notifications (Ch 50) or silent data syncs, correctly per state.
F4	Use push as a trigger; reconcile authoritative state via sync (Ch 32).
F5	Choose priority deliberately; do heavy work off the receiver (WorkManager).
F6	Respect notification permission/consent (Ch 51) and per-account isolation (Ch 42).

Non-functional requirements

Attribute	Target/Policy
Reliability	Dropped/delayed push self-heals via sync; no missing critical state.
Latency	Time-sensitive via high-priority (prompt Doze wake); others normal.
Battery/Quota	High priority only when justified; receiver does minimal work.
Security	No secrets/PII in payload; untrusted input; authed effects; per-account routing.
Correctness	No duplicate/missed notifications across states; idempotent.
Scale	Token storage + fan-out handle millions (backend); client multi-device.

Scope

- **In scope:** FCM integration, notification vs data messages, app-state matrix, token lifecycle (`onNewToken` , server upsert, logout/account invalidation, multi-device), priority/quota (Ch 47), trigger-vs-truth reconciliation (Ch 32), receiver→WorkManager handoff, topics/targeting (client side), notification rendering handoff (Ch 50), permission gating (Ch 51), payload security + per-account isolation.
- **Out of scope:** notification UI/inbox detail (Ch 50), permission UX detail (Ch 51), Doze mechanics (Ch 47), sync algorithm (Ch 32), backend fan-out internals (described, not built), WorkManager internals (Ch 30).

Assumptions & constraints

- Firebase/FCM (HTTP v1 API server-side), `minSdk 24` , `targetSdk` current (Android 13+ notification permission). Hilt, WorkManager, Retrofit/OkHttp (Ch 1). Delivery is best-effort; tokens rotate; payload ≤ ~4KB; high-priority quota is bucket-dependent.

49.3 System Design Fundamentals

- **FCM transport model.** Your backend sends a message to the **FCM HTTP v1 API** (authed via a service account), targeting a **registration token**, a **topic**, or a **device group**. Google's infrastructure holds a persistent, battery-efficient connection to the device and delivers the message to the OS, which routes it to your app (even if killed, subject to limits). It's a **best-effort** channel.
- **Message types (critical distinction):**
    - **Notification message:** payload has a `notification` block. When the app is **backgrounded/killed**, the **system** displays it automatically (you don't run code); the data arrives in the launch intent if tapped. When **foregrounded**, it's delivered to `onMessageReceived` and you display it.
    - **Data message:** payload has only a `data` block. **Always** delivered to `onMessageReceived` (your code), in all states (subject to limits) — you control display. **Recommended** for apps that want consistent control.
    - **Mixed** (both blocks): system shows the notification when backgrounded; data is in the intent. Avoid relying on `onMessageReceived` for mixed messages when backgrounded.

- **App-state × type matrix (the thing to get right):**

State	Notification message	Data message
Foreground	`onMessageReceived` (you show)	`onMessageReceived`
Background	system shows; data in tap intent	`onMessageReceived` (limited by Doze/bucket)
Killed	system shows; data in tap intent	`onMessageReceived` if delivered (more likely dropped/delayed)

  For full control + background sync, use **data messages** with **high priority** for time-sensitive ones — and still reconcile via sync.

- **Token lifecycle.** On first run (and on rotation) FCM issues a **registration token** (`FirebaseMessaging.getToken()` / `onNewToken`). The client must **upsert it to the backend keyed by user + device** (Ch 42 per-account). Tokens **rotate** unpredictably; always honor `onNewToken`. On **logout/account switch**, **delete/ invalidate** the token server-side and locally (Ch 22/42) so the next user doesn't get the previous user's pushes. The server must **prune stale tokens** (FCM returns `UNREGISTERED` / `NOT_FOUND` on send → remove).

- **Priority & Doze (Ch 47).** `high` priority can wake the app in Doze for prompt delivery (limited, **App Standby bucket**-dependent quota); `normal` may be batched/ delayed. Use high **only** for genuinely time-sensitive, user-impacting messages (chat, order status); over-use exhausts quota and gets you throttled. High-priority data message → optionally **expedited WorkManager** (Ch 30) for the follow-up work.

- **Push is a trigger, not the source of truth.** Because delivery is best-effort, **never treat a push as authoritative state**. A push says "something may have changed" → the client does a **delta sync** (Ch 32) over the authed API to get the real state, into the SSOT (Ch 3). This way a **dropped push self-heals** at the next sync/app-open, and a **duplicate push is idempotent** (Ch 15). Critical flows (payments, orders) must not depend solely on push.

- **Receiver discipline.** `onMessageReceived` runs on a background thread with a short budget (~seconds, and heavily limited in Doze). Do **minimal** work: parse, maybe show a notification, and **enqueue WorkManager** (expedited for urgent) for any fetch/sync — don't do network/DB heavy lifting inline.

- **Targeting: per-user tokens** (most control, multi-device via multiple tokens), **topics** (pub/sub broadcast — client `subscribeToTopic`, good for broad segments, but coarse and public-ish so no sensitive targeting), **device groups** (legacy). The client subscribes/unsubscribes to topics per preference and **unsubscribes on logout**.

- **Security:** payloads pass through Google → **no secrets/PII** in them (Ch 28); treat payload fields as **untrusted** (validate, don't `eval`/deep-link blindly, Ch 52); **authenticate the effect** (fetch over authed API, Ch 19); ensure **per-account isolation** (a push for account A must not render under account B, Ch 42) by checking the active account against the payload's target.

Core insight: **FCM is a best-effort, battery-efficient server→client transport; model notification-vs-data messages across foreground/background/killed states (prefer data messages for control), manage the rotating per-user/device token lifecycle (upsert, `onNewToken`, invalidate on logout), choose high priority only for time-sensitive messages within quota, keep the receiver minimal (hand work to WorkManager), and — above all — treat push as a trigger and reconcile authoritative state via sync so dropped/duplicate messages self-heal;**

secure payloads (no secrets, untrusted input, authed effects, per-account isolation) and gate display on notification permission.

49.4 High-Level Architecture


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Components & ownership

- **Backend** emits events → FCM API (targeting + priority).
- `FirebaseMessagingService` receives messages, validates/per-account-checks, and hands off to WorkManager + Notifier.
- **Token manager** upserts/invalidates tokens.
- **Sync** (Ch 32) is the safety net that makes dropped push self-heal (truth lives in the SSOT, not the push).

Direction: event → FCM → OS → service (validate) → WorkManager sync → SSOT → notification; token lifecycle + sync keep it reliable and secure.

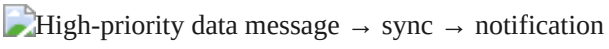
49.5 Detailed Component Design


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Component	Responsibility
`StreamCartMessagingService`	receive messages + token; minimal work; hand off
`FcmTokenManager`	token upsert/rotation/invalidation (per account, Ch 42)
`PushRouter`	validate payload (untrusted), per-account check, classify action
`PushSyncWorker`	expedited delta sync over authed API → SSOT (Ch 30/32/19)
`Notifier`	render notification (channels/grouping, Ch 50), permission-gated (Ch 51)

49.6 End-to-End Data Flow

High-priority data message → sync → notification


High-priority data message → sync → notification

Dropped push self-heals via sync


Dropped push self-heals via sync

Token rotation


Token rotation

49.7 Complete Kotlin Implementation

Package: `com.streamcart.push`.

49.7.1 Manifest + service registration

```
<uses-permission android:name="android.permission.POST_NOTIFICATIONS" />  <!-- Android 13+ (Ch
51) -->

<service
    android:name=".push.StreamCartMessagingService"
    android:exported="false">
    <intent-filter><action android:name="com.google.firebase.MESSAGING_EVENT" /></intent-filter>
</service>
```

49.7.2 FirebaseMessagingService: minimal, hand off

```
@AndroidEntryPoint
class StreamCartMessagingService : FirebaseMessagingService() {
    @Inject lateinit var router: PushRouter
    @Inject lateinit var tokenManager: FcmTokenManager

    override fun onMessageReceived(message: RemoteMessage) {
        // Runs on a background thread with a short budget. Do MINIMAL work; hand off to
WorkManager.
        router.route(message.data, message.notification?.let { NotificationPart(it.title,
it.body) })
    }

    override fun onNewToken(token: String) {
        // Token rotated -> upsert to backend (fire-and-forget via WorkManager so it survives
process death).
        tokenManager.enqueueUpsert(token)
    }
}
```

49.7.3 PushRouter: validate (untrusted), per-account check, enqueue sync

```
@Singleton
class PushRouter @Inject constructor(
    @ApplicationContext private val ctx: Context,
    private val activeAccount: ActiveAccountProvider,   // Ch 42
    private val workManager: WorkManager,
    private val notifier: Notifier,                     // Ch 50
) {
    fun route(data: Map<String, String>, notif: NotificationPart?) {
        // 1) Treat payload as UNTRUSTED input.
        val type = data["type"]?.takeIf { it in KNOWN_TYPES } ?: return   // allowlist, no eval
        val targetAccount = data["acct"]
        // 2) Per-account isolation (Ch 42): drop/stash if not the active account.
        if (targetAccount != null && targetAccount != activeAccount.current()?.id) return
        // 3) Push is a TRIGGER: enqueue expedited sync to fetch authoritative state over authed
API.
        val id = data["id"]
        workManager.enqueue(
            OneTimeWorkRequestBuilder<PushSyncWorker>()
                .setInputData(workDataOf("type" to type, "id" to id))
                .setExpedited(OutOfQuotaPolicy.RUN_AS_NON_EXPEDITED_WORK_REQUEST)   // prompt
(Ch 30/47)
                .build())
        // 4) Optionally show an immediate lightweight notification (content confirmed after
sync).
    }
    companion object { val KNOWN_TYPES = setOf("order_update", "chat_message", "price_drop") }
}
```

49.7.4 PushSyncWorker: fetch truth over authed API → SSOT → notify

```
@HiltWorker
class PushSyncWorker @AssistedInject constructor(
    @Assisted ctx: Context, @Assisted p: WorkerParameters,
    private val syncRepo: SyncRepository,     // Ch 32, authed (Ch 19)
    private val notifier: Notifier,           // Ch 50
) : CoroutineWorker(ctx, p) {
    override suspend fun getForegroundInfo() = ForegroundInfo(/* for expedited on older OS */
...)
    override suspend fun doWork(): Result = runCatching {
        val type = inputData.getString("type") ?: return Result.failure()
        val id = inputData.getString("id")
        val update = syncRepo.fetchAuthoritative(type, id)   // GET over Bearer token;
idempotent (Ch 15)
        notifier.notifyFor(update)                            // render (permission-gated, Ch
50/51)
    }.fold({ Result.success() }, { if (runAttemptCount < 3) Result.retry() else Result.failure()
})
}
```

49.7.5 FcmTokenManager: register, upsert, invalidate on logout

```
@Singleton
class FcmTokenManager @Inject constructor(
    private val firebaseMessaging: FirebaseMessaging,
    private val api: DeviceApi,                  // authed (Ch 19)
    private val workManager: WorkManager,
    private val session: SessionManager,         // Ch 22
) {
    /** Call after login / on app start (while logged in). */
    suspend fun refreshAndUpsert() {
        val token = firebaseMessaging.token.await()
        api.upsertDevice(DeviceDto(deviceId = session.deviceId, token = token))  // keyed by
user+device (Ch 42)
    }
    fun enqueueUpsert(token: String) = workManager.enqueue(
        OneTimeWorkRequestBuilder<TokenUpsertWorker>().setInputData(workDataOf("t" to token))

.setConstraints(Constraints.Builder().setRequiredNetworkType(NetworkType.CONNECTED).build())
            .build())   // survives process death; retried until delivered

    /** On logout / account switch (Ch 22/42): stop pushes for this user. */
    suspend fun invalidateOnLogout() {
        runCatching { api.deleteDevice(session.deviceId) }   // server stops sending
        firebaseMessaging.deleteToken().await()              // rotate token locally
        // unsubscribe from all topics tied to the account:
        // topics.forEach { firebaseMessaging.unsubscribeFromTopic(it).await() }
    }
}
```

49.7.6 Topic subscription (per preference; unsubscribe on logout)

```
suspend fun setMarketingOptIn(enabled: Boolean, fm: FirebaseMessaging) {
    if (enabled) fm.subscribeToTopic("flash_sale").await()
    else fm.unsubscribeFromTopic("flash_sale").await()
    // Never use topics for sensitive/targeted content (coarse, not per-user-secure).
}
```

49.7.7 Module structure

```
:feature:push   StreamCartMessagingService, PushRouter, PushSyncWorker, FcmTokenManager,
TokenUpsertWorker
:core:notifications Notifier (Ch 50), permission (Ch 51)
:core:sync      SyncRepository (Ch 32), authed API (Ch 19)
:core:session   SessionManager, ActiveAccountProvider (Ch 22/42)
```

49.8 Concurrency and Race Conditions

Scenario	Risk	Handling
Duplicate push (FCM re-delivery)	duplicate notification/work	idempotent sync + notification dedupe by id (Ch 15)
Token rotates mid-session	sends fail / wrong device	`onNewToken` → upsert via WorkManager (survives death)
Logout then stale push arrives	wrong user sees data	per-account check (Ch 42) + token invalidation
Receiver does heavy work	dropped/ANR under Doze	hand to WorkManager (expedited)
Multiple pushes trigger overlapping sync	races	`enqueueUniqueWork` / single-flight (Ch 11/30)
Notification shown before truth fetched	wrong content	show after sync, or update notification post-sync
Topic subscribe race on login/logout	cross-account leakage	subscribe on login, unsubscribe on logout (await)

- **Idempotency is mandatory:** FCM can deliver a message more than once and your sync + notification must dedupe by a stable id (Ch 15) so re-delivery doesn't double-notify or double-apply.
- **Token upsert must survive process death:** do it via **WorkManager** (retried), not an inline network call in `onNewToken` (the process may die before it completes).
- **Per-account check guards cross-user leakage:** always compare the payload's target account to the **active** account before rendering/applying (Ch 42); invalidate tokens on logout so the server stops sending.

49.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

Failure	Detection	Response	Outcome
Push dropped (Doze/bucket)	missing notification	delta sync on open/periodic (Ch 32)	self-heals
Delivered but delayed	late notification	high priority for time-sensitive; sync backstop	acceptable
Stale token (send fails)	FCM `UNREGISTERED`	server prunes; client re-registers (`onNewToken`)	restored
Duplicate delivery	double notification	idempotent dedupe by id (Ch 15)	single
Cross-account push	wrong user content	per-account check + logout invalidation (Ch 42)	isolated
Payload tampered/malformed	crash/exploit	validate as untrusted; allowlist types (Ch 52)	safe
No notification permission	silent (Android 13+)	request permission (Ch 51); still sync	data correct
High-priority quota exhausted	throttled/delayed	reduce high-priority volume; normal + sync	within quota


49.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

> **The golden rule: push is a trigger, never the source of truth.** Because FCM is best-effort, correctness comes from reconciling via sync (Ch 32) — then dropped, delayed, and duplicate messages all self-heal. Every other failure (token, account, permission, quota) has a specific fix, but this one principle is what makes push reliable at all.

49.10 Scaling the Implementation

- **Level 1.** FCM integration; data messages → notification; token upsert on login + `onNewToken`.
- **Level 2.** Push-as-trigger + delta sync reconciliation (Ch 32); receiver → expedited WorkManager; notification permission gating (Ch 51).
- **Level 3 — production.** Per-account isolation + logout token invalidation (Ch 42/22); idempotent dedupe; priority discipline; payload validation; topics per preference; notification channels/grouping (Ch 50).
- **Level 4 — large.** Multi-device token management; quota-aware priority (Ch 14/47); push analytics (delivery/open rates); server-side token pruning + fan-out via topics/ device groups; A/B of notification content; consent/preference center (Ch 28).
- **Level 5 — enterprise.** Push reliability SLOs (delivery/latency by bucket/OS/OEM); dead-letter/retry on the backend; multi-region FCM; per-notification-type priority policy; privacy/consent governance; observability of trigger→sync→notify funnel.

Avoid overengineering: for most apps, **data messages + token upsert + push-as- trigger-with-sync + permission gating** is the core. Don't build custom delivery guarantees on top of FCM (sync is your guarantee); don't high-priority everything.

49.11 Alternative Approaches and Trade-offs

Dimension	Option A	Option B	When
Message type	Data message	notification message	Data for control/consistency; notification for simple system-shown broadcasts
Source of truth	Sync (push = trigger)	trust the payload	Always sync-reconcile (push best-effort); never trust payload as truth
Priority	High (time-sensitive)	normal (default)	High only for chat/order-status; normal otherwise (quota, Ch 47)
Follow-up work	Expedited WorkManager	inline in receiver	WorkManager (receiver budget tiny, Doze-limited)
Targeting	Per-user token	topic	Token for personal/secure; topic for broad non-sensitive segments
Real-time transport	FCM push	WebSocket (Ch 63)	FCM for background/killed wake; WebSocket for live foreground session
Token upsert	WorkManager (durable)	inline network	WorkManager (survives process death)

Data vs notification messages: notification messages are simplest (system shows them when backgrounded, no code), but you lose control when backgrounded/killed and can't customize or reconcile reliably. Data messages always reach your code, giving consistent control to validate, per-account-check, sync, and render — at the cost of handling display yourself and running under tighter Doze limits. For a real app that needs correctness and per-account isolation, **prefer data messages** (high priority for time-sensitive) and always reconcile via sync.

Push vs WebSocket for real-time (Ch 63): FCM is the right transport when the app may be **backgrounded or killed** (it wakes the app battery-efficiently via the OS). A WebSocket (Ch 63) is right for a **live foreground session** (chat open, live stream) where you need low-latency bidirectional streaming — but it dies when backgrounded. Real apps use **both**: WebSocket while foregrounded/active, FCM to wake for background events, with sync (Ch 32) as the reconciliation layer behind both.

Push as truth vs push as trigger: trusting the payload as authoritative state is the classic mistake — a dropped push then means permanently missed state, and a duplicate means double-applied changes. Treating push as a **trigger** that prompts an authed, idempotent **sync** (Ch 32/15/19) makes the system self-healing and secure (the payload can even be minimal, avoiding PII). This is the single most important design decision in the chapter.

49.12 Security & Privacy Considerations

- **No secrets or PII in the payload.** Payloads traverse Google's servers and may be logged/cached; send a **minimal signal** (type + id), fetch details over the **authed API** (Ch 19). Never put tokens, full messages, prices tied to identity, etc., in the push (Ch 28).
- **Treat payloads as untrusted input.** Validate/allowlist `type`; never blindly deep-link from a payload (open-redirect/intent-injection risk, Ch 52); never `eval` or trust URLs/ids without server verification.
- **Authenticate the effect.** The notification's data is fetched with the user's auth (Bearer, Ch 19); the push itself grants no access.

- **Per-account isolation (Ch 42).** Check the payload's target account against the **active** account before rendering/applying; **invalidate the token on logout/switch** so the previous user's pushes stop. A chat push for account A must never render under account B.
- **Topics are coarse/semi-public.** Never use topics for sensitive or per-user targeting (anyone who reverse-engineers the app can subscribe); use per-user tokens for anything personal.
- **Notification content on lock screen** must respect sensitivity (public/private versions, Ch 50) and consent (Ch 51/28).
- **Token theft/misuse:** tokens are not secrets that grant access, but a leaked token lets someone send to that device *via your authed backend only* — protect the send API, rotate on logout, and prune stale tokens.
- Client vs backend: the backend owns **token storage (per user/device), fan-out, pruning stale tokens, priority policy, and never embedding PII**; the client owns **validation, per-account routing, sync reconciliation, and permission gating**.

49.13 Performance and Resource Optimization

- **Minimal receiver work** → hand to WorkManager; avoids ANR and Doze drops.
- **High priority sparingly** (quota + battery, Ch 47); batch/coalesce server events so you send fewer, more meaningful pushes (Ch 14).
- **Collapsible messages** (`collapseKey`): let FCM collapse superseded messages (e.g., "3 new messages" replaces older) to save battery/bandwidth.
- **Small payloads** (≤4KB; keep well under) — signal, not content.
- **Coalesce sync triggers:** multiple pushes → unique/debounced sync work (Ch 11/30) rather than N fetches.
- **Notification throttling/grouping** (Ch 50) to avoid spamming + battery from many `notify()` calls.
- **Profiling:** delivery/open funnel, wake-ups and battery attributed to push (Battery Historian), high-priority quota usage, sync-after-push cost.

49.14 Testing Strategy

Push is tested with faked `RemoteMessage`, WorkManager test APIs, and the FCM console/ `adb` for end-to-end.

```
class PushRouterTest {
    @Test fun `drops push for non-active account`() {
        val router = PushRouter(ctx, FakeActiveAccount("A"), fakeWm, fakeNotifier)
        router.route(mapOf("type" to "chat_message", "id" to "1", "acct" to "B"), null)
        assertTrue(fakeWm.enqueued.isEmpty())   // per-account isolation (Ch 42)
    }
    @Test fun `ignores unknown message type`() {
        PushRouter(ctx, FakeActiveAccount("A"), fakeWm, fakeNotifier).route(mapOf("type" to
"evil"), null)
        assertTrue(fakeWm.enqueued.isEmpty())   // allowlist validation
    }
    @Test fun `enqueues expedited sync for known type`() { /* assert WorkManager enqueue */ }
}

class PushSyncWorkerTest {
    @Test fun `sync is idempotent across duplicate pushes`() = runTest {
        val worker = TestListenableWorkerBuilder<PushSyncWorker>(ctx, workDataOf("type" to
"order_update","id" to "1")).build()
        worker.doWork(); worker.doWork()         // twice
        assertEquals(1, fakeNotifier.shown.count { it.id == "1" })   // deduped (Ch 15)
    }
}

class FcmTokenManagerTest {
    @Test fun `invalidateOnLogout deletes device and rotates token`() = runTest { /* assert
deleteDevice + deleteToken */ }
}
```

```
# End-to-end with adb (send a data message to the app):
adb shell am broadcast -a com.google.android.c2dm.intent.RECEIVE ...   # or FCM test console
adb shell dumpsys deviceidle force-idle   # verify high-priority wakes it (Ch 47)
```

What to test: router validation + per-account drop + unknown-type drop; expedited enqueue; idempotent sync (duplicate pushes → one notification); token upsert via WorkManager; logout invalidation; permission-gated rendering (Ch 51); app-state behavior (foreground vs background) on device; Doze high-priority wake.

49.15 Production Observability

- **Metrics:** delivery → open **funnel** (sent / delivered / displayed / tapped); delivery latency and **drop rate by App Standby bucket / OS / OEM** (Ch 47); token upsert success + stale-token prune rate; high-priority **quota usage**; duplicate- delivery rate; per-account mis-route count (should be 0); notification-permission grant rate (Ch 51); sync-after-push success.

- **Logs:** `push{type, priority, delivered_at, synced, notified, account_ok}` — **no PII/ payload content** (Ch 28).
- **Debugging:** missing notifications → drop (Doze/bucket) → rely on sync; late → priority/quota; wrong user → per-account/token invalidation bug; duplicates → non-idempotent; not shown on 13+ → permission; sends failing → stale tokens not pruned.
- **Alerting:** delivery-rate drop on an OS/OEM after update; high-priority quota exhaustion; any cross-account mis-route (security alert).
- **Dashboards:** delivery funnel and drop-by-bucket/OEM; trigger→sync→notify success rate (the reliability KPI).

49.16 System Design Interview Preparation

> ≥40 questions.

Fundamentals

1. *Why not poll?* Doze blocks/defers it, battery/scale — use push (Ch 47).
2. *What is FCM?* Battery-efficient OS-level server→client transport via Google infra; best-effort.
3. *Notification vs data message?* System-shown when backgrounded vs always delivered to your code.
4. *Which to prefer?* Data messages (control/consistency); notification for simple broadcasts.
5. *App-state matrix?* Foreground → your code; background/killed → system shows notification messages, data messages may be dropped/delayed.

Reliability 6. *Is delivery guaranteed?* No — best-effort; may drop/delay/collapse. 7. *Golden rule?* Push is a trigger, not the source of truth. 8. *How dropped push self-heals?* Delta sync on open/periodic (Ch 32). 9. *Duplicate delivery?* Idempotent sync + dedupe by id (Ch 15). 10. *Critical flows (payment) on push alone?* Never — reconcile via sync.

Tokens 11. *Registration token?* Per-install id to target; can rotate. 12. `onNewToken` *?* Rotation callback — upsert to backend. 13. *Store token keyed by?* User + device (multi-device, per-account, Ch 42). 14. *Logout?* Delete/invalidate token + unsubscribe topics. 15. *Stale tokens?* Server prunes on `UNREGISTERED` / `NOT_FOUND`. 16. *Upsert durably?* WorkManager (survives process death).

Priority/Doze 17. *High vs normal priority?* High can wake in Doze (limited quota); normal may be delayed (Ch 47). 18. *When high?* Time-sensitive (chat, order status) only. 19. *Quota?* Bucket-dependent; over-use throttled. 20. *Follow-up work?* Expedited WorkManager, not inline.

Receiver 21. `onMessageReceived` *constraints?* Short budget, background thread, Doze-limited. 22. *What to do inline?* Validate, per-account check, enqueue WorkManager, maybe lightweight notify.

Targeting 23. *Per-user token vs topic vs device group?* Control/secure vs broad pub/sub vs legacy. 24. *Topics for sensitive content?* No — coarse/semi-public. 25. *Subscribe/unsubscribe lifecycle?* On preference change; unsubscribe on logout.

Security 26. *Secrets/PII in payload?* Never (traverses Google). 27. *Payload trust?* Untrusted — validate/allowlist; no blind deep-link (Ch 52). 28. *Authenticate the effect?* Fetch over authed API (Ch 19). 29. *Per-account isolation?*

Check active account vs payload; invalidate on logout (Ch 42). 30. *Token a secret?* No, but protect the send API; rotate/prune.

Push vs WebSocket 31. *When WebSocket?* Live foreground session (Ch 63). 32. *When FCM?* Background/killed wake. 33. *Use both?* Yes — WS foreground, FCM background, sync reconciles.

Permissions/UX 34. *Android 13+ display?* Needs `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` (Ch 51). 35. *No permission?* Data still syncs; just not shown. 36. *Notification rendering?* Central Notifier, channels/grouping (Ch 50).

Testing/Production 37. *Test the router?* Fake `RemoteMessage`; assert validation/per-account/enqueue. 38. *Test idempotency?* Run sync twice → one notification. 39. *Missing notifications in prod?* Drops (Doze/bucket) → rely on sync. 40. *Wrong user sees push?* Per-account/token invalidation bug. 41. *Sends failing?* Stale tokens not pruned. 42. *Key reliability KPI?* Trigger→sync→notify success + delivery-by-bucket.

Design-change challenges

1. **Design push for chat.** Data message (high priority) → fetch message → grouped notification; WebSocket when foregrounded; sync reconciles; per-account isolation.
2. **Order-status push must never be missed.** Push as trigger + authoritative order sync (Ch 32); don't depend on delivery.
3. **Users report pushes for the wrong account after switching.** Per-account check + token invalidation on switch (Ch 42).
4. **Battery/quota complaints from too many high-priority pushes.** Downgrade non-urgent to normal; coalesce/collapse; sync backstop (Ch 47).
5. **Notifications not showing on Android 13+.** Request `POST_NOTIFICATIONS`; data still syncs (Ch 51).

Mock walkthrough (abridged)

Clarify (what events, how time-sensitive, multi-account/device, foreground live too?) → FCM transport + message type (data) → token lifecycle (upsert/rotate/invalidate) → priority policy (Ch 47) → **push-as-trigger + sync reconciliation** (Ch 32) → receiver → expedited WorkManager → per-account isolation + payload security (Ch 42/28/52) → notification rendering + permission (Ch 50/51) → push vs WebSocket (Ch 63) → observability (delivery funnel, drop-by-bucket).

49.17 Practical Exercises

1. **Beginner.** Integrate FCM: receive a data message, show a notification, upsert the token on login and in `onNewToken`. *Eval:* message received across states; token stored.
2. **Intermediate.** Make push a trigger: on receipt, enqueue an expedited WorkManager delta sync over the authed API; show the notification after truth is fetched. *Eval:* dropped push self-heals on next sync.
3. **Advanced.** Add per-account isolation + logout token invalidation + idempotent dedupe. *Eval:* no cross-account rendering; duplicates → one notification; logout stops pushes.
4. **Production debugging.** Diagnose "notifications missing in prod": confirm drops by bucket, verify sync backstop, and fix a stale-token pruning gap. *Eval:* reliability restored; stale tokens pruned.
5. **System design challenge.** Design chat real-time using FCM (background) + WebSocket (foreground) + sync (reconcile), with priority policy and a delivery funnel dashboard. *Eval:* correct across states; self-healing;

observable.

(Solutions withheld unless requested.)

49.18 Chapter Summary & Reference Sheet

Key decisions: use **FCM** as a **best-effort, battery-efficient server→client transport**; prefer **data messages** (consistent code control across app states) with **high priority only for time-sensitive** events (bucket-limited quota, Ch 47); manage the **token lifecycle** rigorously (register, `onNewToken`, durable WorkManager upsert keyed by **user+device**, **invalidate on logout/account switch**, server prunes stale tokens); keep `onMessageReceived` **minimal** and hand follow-up work to **expedited WorkManager** (Ch 30); and above all treat **push as a trigger, reconciling authoritative state via sync** (Ch 32) so **dropped, delayed, and duplicate messages self-heal** (idempotent, Ch 15) — never trust the payload as truth; **secure** it (no secrets/PII, untrusted input, authed effects via Ch 19, **per-account isolation** via Ch 42, topics only for coarse non-sensitive segments); **gate display on** `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` (Ch 51) and render via a central **Notifier** (Ch 50); and combine FCM (background) with a **WebSocket** (foreground live, Ch 63) when real-time matters.

Concepts: FCM transport, notification vs data messages, app-state matrix, token lifecycle/rotation/invalidation, priority & Doze quota, push-as-trigger + sync reconciliation, receiver→WorkManager handoff, topics/targeting, per-account isolation, payload security, permission gating, FCM vs WebSocket.

Common mistakes: treating push as the source of truth (dropped = lost); heavy work in the receiver; not handling `onNewToken`/not pruning stale tokens; high-priority everything (quota throttle); PII in payload; trusting payload (blind deep-link); no per-account check / no logout invalidation (cross-account leak); topics for sensitive targeting; no `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` handling; non-idempotent (duplicates).

Checklist: ☐ data messages + deliberate priority ☐ token upsert (user+device, durable)

- `onNewToken` ☐ invalidate token + unsubscribe topics on logout ☐ receiver minimal → expedited WorkManager ☐ **push = trigger; reconcile via sync** ☐ idempotent dedupe by id ☐ validate payload (allowlist, no blind deep-link) ☐ authed effect (Ch 19) ☐ per-account isolation (Ch 42) ☐ no secrets/PII in payload ☐ `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` gating ☐ delivery funnel + drop-by-bucket telemetry.

Key APIs: `FirebaseMessagingService`/`onMessageReceived`/`onNewToken`, `FirebaseMessaging.getToken`/`deleteToken`/`subscribeToTopic`/`unsubscribeFromTopic`, `RemoteMessage` (data/notification), FCM HTTP v1 API (server), `priority: high|normal`, `collapseKey`, `CoroutineWorker.setExpedited`/`OutOfQuotaPolicy` (Ch 30), `POST_NOTIFICATIONS` (Ch 51), `NotificationCompat` (Ch 50).

References:

- FCM overview: https://firebase.google.com/docs/cloud-messaging
- Message types: https://firebase.google.com/docs/cloud-messaging/concept-options
- Receive messages on Android: https://firebase.google.com/docs/cloud-messaging/android/receive
- Manage tokens: https://firebase.google.com/docs/cloud-messaging/manage-tokens
- Notifications & Doze/priority: https://firebase.google.com/docs/cloud-messaging/concept-options#setting-the-priority-of-a-message

- (composes) Ch 47 Doze/Limits, Ch 30 WorkManager, Ch 32 Delta Sync, Ch 19 Auth, Ch 42 Multi-Account, Ch 50 Notifications, Ch 51 Permissions, Ch 63 WebSockets

Chapter review (Phase 4)

- **Completeness:** all 18 sections; architecture/class/3 sequence+flow/failure diagrams; messaging service + router (validate/per-account) + expedited sync worker + token manager + topics code; concurrency (idempotency, token-durability, per-account); failure (drop/token/account/dupe/perm/quota triage with golden rule); 5 levels; data-vs- notification, push-vs-WebSocket, trigger-vs-truth trade-offs; security/privacy (no PII, untrusted, authed, per-account, topics); perf (minimal receiver, collapse, coalesce); router/worker/token tests + adb; observability (delivery funnel, drop-by-bucket); 42 Q&A + 5 challenges. ✅
- **Expand later:** notifications UI (Ch 50), permissions (Ch 51), WebSockets (Ch 63), sync (Ch 32).
- **Interview coverage:** exceeds ≥40 Complex bar.